KOLKATA DIARIES

Fifteen Years, a Masterpiece of Ruin

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This is a work of memoir. Experiences are recorded as they were lived and told. Private persons appear unnamed or under respect; public figures and songwriters appear only as documented history. Song lyrics are quoted in brief for criticism and tribute.
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The sad is so sharp it cuts with smell.

If you had loved me once for even a second,

that would be my truth.

— to my wife

THE MOMENT

A song came in softly.

Not announcing itself. Just arriving. Young faces in sunlight.

Grass. Bicycles. A ball field. People laughing. A hand. A look.

A room at night. A kitchen light. Life happening without knowing

it would someday become memory.

Then the music touched that one sharp minute, and underneath

the warmth a thin blade appeared. Not enough to make me cry.

Just enough to realize:

this moment is already gone.

My senses filled in what the video could not show. Old fabric.

Warm wood. Dust. Sun-heated pavement. Someone's perfume. Night

air through a window. The faint smell of food. Rain somewhere

outside. The particular smell of a house belonging to another

time. Ten smells. Fifteen. They did not arrive separately.

They arrived as one memory.

For a few seconds I was not watching 1986. I was standing

inside my own fifteen years. I could smell another year. Not

remember it. Smell it.

The people on the screen did not know they were being

remembered. They were simply alive.

Name the song and the film, because the songs deserve their

titles the way the dead deserve their names: "Living Inside

My Heart," Bob Seger, 1986 — from About Last Night, the film

with Demi Moore and Rob Lowe, a nostalgia-driven love story that looked, for three and a half minutes, like a sports film of the heart. The lyric does not talk about the ending at all. It talks about the sun coming up:

"When the sun came up this morning
And she smiled her smile for me
I felt it for the first time
Something deep inside of me..."
"She's living inside my heart now."

Present tense. Now. The song was recorded decades ago and it still speaks in the present tense — because that is what the heart does. It keeps the smile in the morning light forever, and hides the invoices where the music cannot see them. I went in expecting nothing. I was not aware that it would cut me like that.

And the cut did one more thing, maybe intended, maybe not: it did not slow down. It did not give me enough time to cry. And I understood, sitting there, that this was the truest portrait of the fifteen years themselves: each and every moment passed so fast that I was not able to laugh or smile or cry. Not enough time. It passed so fast.

Kolkata was fast for me. Every moment of it.

I cherish it.

One sentence got written that night, and the sentence became this book:

The sad is so sharp it cuts with smell.

And one suspicion got written with it, only half a joke, the way the truest things always arrive:

Maybe the eighties and the nineties were made just so they could be played back at us in 2026. Maybe it was a conspiracy of God. He hid the time bombs in the sweetest decades — the songs, the films, the footage of young faces who did not know they were being filmed — and then He waited, patiently, for the exact night when a man with fifteen years of gold behind him would press play.

And now that I have gathered the evidence, the file is bigger than the eighties. Look at the arsenal — this book holds eight of His charges, and their manufacture dates stretch across a century: Seger, 1986. Air Supply, 1983. Roxette, 1986. Tagore — early 1900s. Borno Chakroborty. And the Bengal division of the conspiracy: Anupam Roy and Rupankar Bagchi, this very decade, building bombs for a man who would need them in the 2020s. Two languages. One hundred years. Different continents, same munitions factory.

That is not a genre. That is a supply chain. Every era thought it was writing love songs. Every era was loading ammunition for someone's 3 AM in 2026.

God does not spring His traps early. He waited until the man had lived enough to lose something. Then He sent a soft song from 1986 to do what no argument could: prove that the past is not past at all — it is stored, whole, in the smell of a room nobody has entered in years.

If it was a conspiracy, it was the kindest one ever committed. He weaponized nostalgia not to wound us, but to make us look down at the ground while it is still golden. This book will not give you time to cry. Neither did the fifteen years.

Movement I — The City Arrives

Kolkata did not welcome me. It absorbed me.
Other cities show you their best roads first. Kolkata showed me its heartbeat: yellow taxis moving like patient yellow blood cells through veins too narrow for them, tram lines sleeping in their grooves, a hand out of a taxi window meaning ten different things, noise that was not noise but weather.
Year one, I was a tourist pretending to be a resident. Year two, the city stopped letting me pretend. Year three, I had a route, a tea stall, a seat on the bus quietly understood to be mine —
and an evening signal that would become the most important place in my life.
I did not know any of this was beginning.
You never do.

I-A — One Suitcase

Kolkata did not begin as a marriage.

It began as a signature bachelor life — a life started from scratch, on a platform of nothing. I landed there with a suitcase in my hand. One suitcase. That's it.

A heart already broken — Bangalore had done that — and a question I would not have dared to ask out loud: can a man heal in a city that owes him nothing?

First door I walked through was the office. And the office was not an office.

It was a residential house. A real house, turned into a company. The director who received me — Arup Bose, revered from the first meeting, respected before I understood why — was kind, and something in the place was different. Not the posh office, not the IT-company glass-and-steel. Nirupan da moving through the rooms with a towel on his shoulder. Nirupan da cooking the meals. The whole office eating food cooked in the same kitchen where the walls still held their old family paint.

It was not a shock. It was a sweet shock.

Something in me was healing. Slowly, without announcement, in the smell of that kitchen — the way a broken bone mends in sleep. The PG aunty and uncle after that, showing their love to a stranger from another state, feeding him like a son.

And there was a song, always, in that first year. The Autograph song — Anupam Roy's "Beche Thakar Gaan." I misheard

it for years as a song about city stories. It is not. It is a refusal. Hear the actual words:

"Jodi kere nite bole kobita thasha khata,
jeno kere nite debo na…"

If they say: hand over the notebook filled with poems — I will not give it up.

"Jodi chhere jete bole shohure koto kotha,
jeno ami chharte debo na…"

If they say: let go of the city's many stories — I will not let go.

"Ami jani jani — chorabali kotokhani gileche
amader rod…"

I know, I know — the quicksand has swallowed our sunshine, a little more every day.

That is what the song says: the world will ask you to hand over the notebook. The quicksand of ordinary time will eat the sunshine daily, and it will ask, politely, for the notebook too — the poems, the stories, the afternoons. I will not give it up.

That was the medicine of the healing year. A man from Bangalore with one suitcase and a broken heart heard a stranger sing the vow his whole life would need — and hummed along, not knowing he was signing.

New timeline. New beginning. I could feel the heat through the taxi window on the way to office — Kolkata was hot, humid but warm. Still warm.

And the eighties, as if it had been waiting for exactly this kind of man, sent its anthem. Air Supply — "Making Love Out of Nothing at All." Listen to what the man sings, verse after verse: I know just how to whisper. I know just how to lie. I know the roads to riches, the ways to fame, all the rules and how to break them —

a fortress-builder's resume. Every skill a man armors himself with. And then the chorus arrives and the armor is confessed as costume:

"But I don't know how to leave you,

and I'll never let you fall."

Everything I know — the singing says — is nothing,

until I give it to you.

That was the promise of my Kolkata years, sung before they happened. I arrived with one suitcase and a skill set; out of a borrowed PG, a rented hall, a kitchen that was not ours — out of nothing at all — she and I would make a life. The song says making love. I say making a life. In the end they were the same act.

Remember that warmth. This whole book is its autopsy.

We were three friends in those days — the two of them half my age, teenagers when I was in my thirties. One year in the PG, then a rented house with a big hall, and Rajib — Rajib, who loved me so much, and who taught me the lesson I did not know I had come to Kolkata to learn:

You do not lose your manhood by showing love.

He loved unconditionally, openly, without irony — a thing no one had ever demonstrated to me in daylight. I had crossed a country to find work, and what I found was a man showing me the one skill my father's generation had taught its sons to hide.

I kept the lesson. Everything good in this book is built on it.

I-B — The Wedding

Then came matrimony, and then came her — into my life's heart.

Before the wedding, we would meet — quietly, the way Kolkata allows: a rented house with a big hall that still felt artificial to me, borrowed furniture, borrowed life — and she would come anyway, and sit beside me while I slept the afternoon sleep. (The afternoon. Even then it was already the signature of Kolkata — the signature of my fifteen years. You cannot imagine.)

And the wedding day itself. The ceremony, the oath, the old rituals. She sat beside me.

I did not look at her. Not once.

She asked me later — why? Why did you not look at me once?

Because, I told her — you looked so beautiful that I did not have the courage.

I was feeling shy. A man in his thirties, shy at his own wedding, eyes on the fire instead of the woman beside him, because some light is too strong to look at directly and the rituals knew it — that's why the fire gets the vow instead of the eyes.

She deserved a better look than I gave her that day.

The rest of this book is me, finally, looking.

I-C — The Furnace

And because this book refuses to skip, it must also hold
the other signature — the one nobody photographs.
Kolkata's funerals have a signature too. Keoratola. The
chamber. The furnace — not the wooden pyre of the old verses,
but the machine: the body rolls in, the fire takes it, within
one hour the whole biography of a human being is steam and
ash and a small clay pot.
Both her parents went through that furnace. I stood present
at both burnings — her mother, her father — holding her
place in the world while the fire held theirs. I witnessed
the fire that does not negotiate — the same city that served
biryani and puja and taxi-rides also owns the room where
every story in it ends.
Life and death, both signatures, one city. The whole cycle
in the same postcode — the meals and the furnace, the wedding
fire and the funeral fire, the same element, invited twice.
The city taught me its final lesson the way it taught me
everything: without pausing.
The furnace does not give you time to cry either.
It runs on schedule. Like the signal.

Movement II — The Signal

Every evening, on the way back from office, there was a signal. Not a famous crossing. Not a postcard. A signal. Red light. Idling engines. The white striped ground. Vendors moving between cars with trays held at exactly the height of a car window. The yellow taxi ahead with its boot slightly open. A child asleep on a two-wheeler against its father's back.

Two hundred and fifty days a year. I did not do the arithmetic then. Nobody does. The signal was not an event. It was the white space around the text of my day — and everything important in those fifteen years happened in the margins.

I planned evenings there. I rehearsed conversations there that I would never have. I forgave people there who would never know. I let the day's anger drain out through the soles of my shoes into the warm asphalt. I watched red turn to amber the way other men pray.

Later — when everything was taken — it was not the office I missed.

It was the signal.

The body remembered standing still. The honey light of five-thirty. Diesel and frying oil and river-damp, all in one breath. One day, without permission, the body served it up whole, and the sad cut with smell — the sentence had not been written

yet.

If you have a signal in your life, know this: it is keeping something for you.

You will not know what until the city is gone.

Movement III — The Yellow Taxis

The taxis were yellow the way the sun is warm. Not a color. A decision the universe made and then kept.

The drivers knew the city the way priests know liturgy. They argued politics with their hands on the wheel. They had opinions about everything and the leisure to hold them.

One memory stands above the others, kept in its original condition, unimproved by retelling:

A taxi. Evening. Rain just ended, streets as dark glass, windows fogged so the city outside became an impressionist's mistake. The seat under me held the smell of old vinyl and twenty years of sun and a thousand previous passengers dissolved into the material.

Beside me, sometimes, was her.

I will get to her. The book is walking toward her and she knows it, and I am walking as slowly as I can.

Because this part of the road is where the good years live.

Movement IV — The Office Years

Fifteen years is three jobs, or two marriages, or one career,
or one whole adult youth.
For me it was one long middle act. Wake. Dress. The commute —
not dead time, transition time, the hour where the
house-self closed its door and the working-self opened its
own. The work. The lunch that was never enough of a break and
always exactly enough. The slow sag of afternoon. Then the
return — the best part, when the city belonged to no one and
everyone.
I was the man who was good at the thing. For fifteen years.
Nobody tells you that a job is a form of love.
The office years smelled like morning soap and metro
brake-dust, machine-oil in the lift, tea from a cracked cup,
the carbon-smell of the printer running long, sweat and starch
at four o'clock — and the Outside, that great city breath
waiting at the gate at six like a dog that has learned your
schedule.
I was not unhappy. The war came later. These were the years
the fortress was being built.
If you are living them now, in your own city, at your own
signal:
You are standing inside the good days. They will not
announce themselves.

They will just be Tuesday.

Movement V — Her

Now the hardest movement. Written the only way I can — from this side of the room. What she felt is not mine to tell. That room was never mine to describe.

There was no lightning. There was a sequence of Tuesdays. There was a conversation that went on too long in the good direction. There was the discovery, made slowly and then all at once, that the body braces around some people — and around her, mine relaxed.

We ate. God, how we ate. Biryani with the potato Bengalis will defend with their lives. Rolls folded in paper gone transparent with heat and grease. A roshogolla, which is not a sweet but a physics of syrup and surrender. We argued about which counter was best the way other couples argue about money.

It was the happiest argument of my life. I would give a year to have it again.

We watched films in halls where fans did not defeat the heat but negotiated with it. In the dark, shoulder against shoulder, screen light falling on a face I was not watching the film to see. We came out into the night with the story still dissolving in us, walked to the taxi stand, and the city drove us home in its yellow carriages like the world's most patient chaperone.

We had a room. The physical one and the other one — the one made of routine and trust: which cup is whose, which side of the bed, the joke that only works because of the night it was born on. The room smelled of laundry and rain and her perfume and, in the evenings, food. Some nights the window was open and the city came in — horns, someone's television, the elevator's complaint —

and none of it was noise. All of it was the sound of the life we had built being audible.

And the afternoons taught me the city — or rather, she did, through the afternoons. The signature afternoon, one more time, but a different premise: the doctor's visit. Then lunch after, in the Das cabin at Gariahat, the two of us with the appointment behind us and the whole evening ahead. The checkup made the meal an occasion; the meal made the day a memory; and none of it was planned.

Gariahat market. I still remember Gariahat. The crowd, the stalls, the noise — and I standing patiently while she bargained. I did not know the words she used. I did not need to. The bargaining was music in a language where I only knew the refrain, and the refrain was: we have all afternoon.

The same at the mall. She would look at clothes she had no intention of buying — hold them against the light, ask the price, put them back with ceremony. And I would wait. Patiently. A fortress-builder, standing still among the racks, learning from a woman who never rushed: that the looking is

the point. That wanting, held long enough, becomes its own keepsake.

And she taught me the language.

The proper Bengali. The Kolkata language — not the textbook kind, the street kind, the kind that lets you stand in a market and be answered. After fifteen years I speak it still.

A man can lose a wife and keep her grammar; the language she taught is the part of her that talks to me every time I open my mouth in that city.

She taught me where to go. Which direction. Which lane held what, which counter treated you fair, which hour the crowd thinned. Every street, every nook and corner — guided by her, corrected by her, made native by her.

I know each and every beat because of her.

The city did not raise me.

She did. The city was only the classroom.

And once a year, the city itself fell in love.

You never saw Durga Puja coming first. You smelled it.

Kash phool. The white feathery flowers on the roadside grass, arriving in the last heat of September like the year's first letter from a festival that was still weeks away. One day the city was just the city, and the next day the kash was standing in the gaps between the pavement slabs, in the cracks of the verge, silver-white and bending — and something in the chest unlocked. The smell of the grass, the smoke starting somewhere in the lanes, the first dhaak rehearsals echoing from a

community hall —

A full year of ordinary days, and this is how the city
invited us: not with posters, not with announcements.
With a flower that smelled like childhood, blooming exactly
where no one plants anything.
Then the four days themselves.
Pandal hopping on a hot evening that stretched into night,
and the night kept none of the day's heat but all of its
excitement. Thousands of us moving through the lanes on foot,
a river of people in new clothes, the theme-pandals glowing
like lanterns of impossible architecture, the dhaak rolling
through the dark like weather, dhunuchi smoke — coconut husk
and incense — folding over the crowds in golden waves. The
lights. The queues that were themselves a festival. Her new
sari. The sweat and the sweetness and the drums —
Love, at those hours, could not be expressed. It did not
need to be. It moved the way the crowd moved: together,
toward light, without instruction.
Four days a year the city proved what it had been
practicing all along at that signal — that strangers, standing
close, waiting for the same thing, are not strangers.
And then Ma Durga left, and the immersion came, and the
river took the clay back —
and the city, which does nothing slowly, went back to being
ordinary overnight.
That was the cruelty and the lesson of the four days. Even

the year's biggest love is given a departure date. Even the goddess goes home.

And between the market and the festival, there was the afternoon I keep above all the afternoons.

We came back from an invitation. Tired, the way only a Kolkata afternoon can make you tired. We slept. Both of us. In daylight, in our clothes half-undone, the invitation still folded on the table, the room smelling of talc and sweat and the lunch eaten at someone else's expense.

And the sun came in.

Through the window, late-afternoon rays fell across our room — across the bed, across the folded invitation, across the floor where our slippers stood where they had stepped out of them. Dust moved in the light slow and golden and completely unhurried, each mote taking its whole time in the air. The rays lay across her and across me like something the day had left at the door. Two travelers asleep, and the sun standing watch. Saying: I will be here when you wake.

Kolkata's sun is a hammer at noon. But between three and five, in a closed room, through a window, it is the softest gold there is — and it fell on us as if the city itself had drawn a curtain of light around the only two people in the world too tired to notice.

We did not see those rays. We were asleep.

That is why I trust them. The things you see, you can doubt. The things that happened over you while you slept — the light

that kept its appointment with your room — those are the mercies that need no witness.

There is a Tagore song for this — the city makes sure of that — and Borno Chakroborty sings it like the inside of a quiet rented house while the afternoon passes outside: "Bhalobeshe Shakhi, Nibhrite Jotone."

With love, my darling, in quiet, gentle care,
write my name in the temple of your mind.
Hold my face close with tenderness.
Whisper my words from the deepest part of your heart.

Before the loss, that song is a promise two people make in the dark. After the loss, it reverses its polarity and becomes something else entirely — her voice, asking to be remembered. Write my name. Hold my face with tenderness. Keep me in the quietest room you own.

The afternoon nap was that song, sung by sunlight instead of lyrics. We were the verse. The room was the temple. And the name written in quiet, gentle care —
was ours.

Happiness that knows itself is already performance. Happiness that sleeps through the afternoon is the real thing — and it came to us in daylight, unearned, unguarded, and gone before either of us woke.

There is one more truth, and this book made a promise to tell it without armor. So I will tell it exactly, and then I will not return to it. Some rooms are for one confession only.

In the deepest moments of our intimacy — the ones the body remembers before the mind can refuse — I would close my eyes. Understand why. Not absence. Not escape.

Because looking would have made it real. And real things end. Eyes closed, the moment could be permanent — held outside of time, the way the signal held the evening, the way the afternoon held the sun. My eyes were not rejecting her. My eyes were the only door I knew for keeping a thing forever.

And the deepest of those moments — the most intense, the most intimate — did not end the way the world says such moments end.

They ended in tears.

Hers, mine, both — that is on the other side of the room. But that they ended in tears — that I carry, and that I record: the body reaching its limit of receiving love, and the tear being what pours out instead. The world calls that a failure of the moment. The world is wrong. It is the moment being too true to survive its own edges.

Understand what the vow actually was, because the world misunderstands this every day. When you love someone, you do not only fall for her beauty.

You accept every human defect she comes with.

That is the whole transaction, and there is no fine print: the moods and the silences, the wrong words at the wrong hours, the fears she never explained and the ones she did, the ordinary flaws that a hundred films have taught us to

edit out of the frame. None of it was tolerated. All of it was accepted. Beauty opens the door; the defects are what make you stay in the room.

And that is why the tears could come at the deepest moments — not despite the defects, but because even with them, with all of them, the second was real. A perfect woman might have earned admiration.

A real one earned tears.

There is a song that already knew — Rupankar Bagchi singing it in Jaatishwar — and the question in it is the question I have been answering this whole movement:

"E tumi kemon tumi —
chokher taray ayna dhoro.
E kemon kanna tumi —
amay jokhan aador koro."

What kind of person are you,
holding a mirror in the pupils of your eyes?
What kind of tears are these,
that fall when you caress me?

Tears, during the caress. The most intimate moment ending not in the body's triumph but in the soul's overflow — and the song dares to ask it without shame: what KIND of tears?

The kind that carry whole lifetimes in them:

"Ashrur ekti photay jonmo amar,
amar moron."

In a single teardrop lies my birth,

and my death.

One teardrop. The wedding and the furnace, the first sunlight in the PG and the last sunlight in the room — a whole fifteen-year life cycle, held in one drop of salt water that fell at the wrong moment by the world's clock and the right moment by the heart's.

And here is what the films will never show you, because the films sell the falling, not the staying: the credits always roll at the wedding, at the reunion, at the moment the music swells — as if the promise ends at its sweetest point. Nobody films the morning after the honeymoon budget ends. Nobody films the accepted defects in daylight — year after year, the same table, the same defects, the same choosing. Nobody films the tears that arrive instead of the ending the world promised.

That is marriage. Not shown in films. The reality.

This book is not about the falling. Any fool can fall.

This book is about the staying — and about the man who learned too late how loudly the staying counts, and how quietly it is taken for granted, by everyone, including the two people doing it.

The videos of those years, if they existed, would look like that 1986 song: joy and wreckage in the same reel, no transitions, because that is how it lives in the body. The happy scenes are not scenes. They are the broken present replaying what it cannot put down.

Sadness disguised as happy moments. The disguise is the structure. The cut is the blade. The smell is what lands.

Movement VI — The War Begins

It did not announce itself as illness.

It arrived as a change of weather. The nights lengthened first. Sleep, the reliable servant, began making excuses. The mind — my great asset — began to run at hours when I did not want it running.

For years the line had held: the eagle, the high solving part of the mind; the ground, the ordinary man who needs schedules, food, work, return. The war began as a dispute about jurisdiction. The eagle started filing claims on the night.

Then the day. Then everything. The thoughts came at 2 AM with the confidence of 1 PM.

Somewhere a man is reading this at 3 AM and he needs it said exactly:

it felt like being two people and being housed in neither. It felt like watching your own life through glass that was somehow both too close and too far.

It felt like the signal. Standing still while everything moved.

The saddest sentence in this book is not about what was taken.

During those years the good days were still happening — meals, films, the city at evening, her in the next room — and I was not fully there for them. The war consumed the margins.

And the margins are where the life is.

Some of the evenings at that signal, I was there in body only, fighting in the sky, while the ground — the golden ground, the honey light, the yellow taxis, her — waited for me to look down.

To the man I was then: you were not weak. You were at war. But I wish you had looked down more.

Movement VII — The Truce

The war ended the way real wars end. Not with victory.
With terms.
Five to nine, the eagle flies. At nine, it comes home.
Not a cure. A treaty. A border drawn at last in the right
place, after all the wrong places had failed. The first night
of the truce, I asked the mind what it wanted. It answered in
silence —
and the silence, for the first time in years, was not the
silence of absence. It was the silence of a soldier putting
down a rifle.
No shame on this page: the little white tablets did what the
fortress could not do for itself. A man who takes insulin is
not surrendered to his body. A man who takes his mind's
medicine is not surrendered to his mind. Both are just men who
intend to keep living.
What I honor is the surrender that worked: accepting the only
peace ever on offer. Separation done right. The line. The
beholder standing on the ground, watching the flight —
coming home at nine.

Movement VIII — The Leaving

Then came the day the city let me go.
No one warns you that a whole life can fit into a few bags.
Fifteen years — the office, the room, the tables, the dark halls, the signal — reduced to luggage and a last look around a space that had heard every version of my voice.
Kolkata did not argue. The city has watched every kind of leaving for three centuries. It gave me the face it gives everyone: here before you, here after you.
Leaving a city of fifteen years is not one pain. It is a thousand small amputations. The tea stall that will never know you stopped coming. The bus seat, taken by a stranger. The bend of road where evening light hit a certain wall. The doctor who knew your history. The table by the window. The room.
On the last day, without asking, the whole city served itself up one final time: diesel and river, frying oil, wet stone after rain, the inside of the taxi, the office lift, the room at night.
Ten smells. Fifteen. A thousand. All at once.
The sad was so sharp it cut with smell.
I carried the wound out of the city. The city, which owes no one anything, carried nothing out at all.
To it, you were weather. To you, it was climate.

And the leaving had a soundtrack already waiting, written by a man who had clearly stood where I stood. Anupam Roy — "Boba Tunnel." The title alone: the mute tunnel — the dark silent passage of grief where the screams go unheard. And then, inside it, the two questions every man who has ever left a city of love carries out with him:

"Ami tomar kotha bolbo kake?"

To whom will I speak of you?

"Jodi konodin tumi du haat diye jhinuk kurao —

nei ami."

If someday you gather seashells with both hands —

I will not be there.

The song knows the real grief is not the big scenes. It is the small broken stories — "shei olpo bhanga golpogulo" — the slightly damaged everyday tales, and having no one to toss them to on the walk home at midnight. Fifteen years of stories, and the teller walks back alone.

It walked along the lifeline — "ayurekha dhore" — and regretted only the delay: it took too long to answer what the palm already knew.

And after the tunnel, the room. Roxette opens with three words spoken like a verdict, not a lyric:

"It's over now."

Lay a whisper on my pillow.

I wake up lonely — there's air of silence

in the bedroom and all around.

The bedroom. The same geography as the afternoon nap, the same window, the same fan — and the same air, now holding silence instead of her breathing. That is what a room does after a love: it keeps every dimension of the memory except the person.

"It must have been love — but it's over now.
It must have been good — but I lost it somehow.
From the moment we touched,
'til the time had run out."

Must have been. The past tense with doubt stapled to it — that is the grammar of grief. The world demands certainty at funerals: did you love, did she love, was it real. And the survivor stands with a whisper: it must have been. I was there. It must have been.

But the chorus, which the whole world sings as a breakup song, is actually the most precise sentence in this book:

"From the moment we touched,
'til the time had run out."

From the touch to the time. That is the exact measure of the fifteen years. Everything between those two brackets — the taste of it, the terror of it, the kash phool of it — lives in the space the song leaves between its own two lines.

It's where the water flows. It's where the wind blows.

Movement IX — The Room in Assam

The second act begins in a different state, in a house that belongs to my childhood, with a mother who prays and a mind that had finally learned the treaty.

Assam is green where Kolkata was gold. The air carries rain and vegetation and a river that has not been asked to carry a city. The mornings are quiet in a way that took me a year to stop suspiciously waiting for the other noise.

Then the mind — given its five to nine, its medicine, its treaty — began to produce again. This time the ordinary man was at the desk too.

Out of that room came a fortress: software systems, a filmmaking studio built from code — seven stages, a virtual crew. And seven books.

Seven.

The eagle writing. The ground editing, ordering, beholding.

And now this book — walking toward the film it was always going to become: Kolkata, fifteen years, the signal, the taxis, her —

shot in light that smells the way the city smelled.

I live between two cities now. One outside the window, green and forgiving. One inside the window, gold and gone — the one I can only enter when a song arrives softly, or a smell arrives uninvited, or a yellow taxi passes on a screen.

Memory, rendered honestly, is the one city that never falls.

And the last song of the four came only now, from the female voice — Lagnajita's "Bawshonto Eshe Geche." Spring has arrived, says the song — the same spring, and then, quietly, the bridge that rearranges everything:

"Ei bawshonte, onek jonmo aage —
tomay prothom dekhechhilem ami."
In this spring, many lifetimes ago,
I saw you for the first time.

Many lifetimes ago. Not this one. The love that fits a whole city, a whole marriage, a whole fifteen-year arc into one chest was never a first draft. And the song prices it exactly:

"Shei bawshonto ekhon bhishon dami."
That spring is now incredibly expensive.

It cannot be bought back. It can only be cherished — which is the economy this entire book runs on. The spring was priceless while we slept through it. It is expensive now, in the only currency that still accepts it: attention. Which is what these pages are.

Movement X — The One-Second Truth

This final movement is short, because it is a vow, and vows should be short.

To her.

I am not asking for a single hour back. I am not asking the past to re-file itself under a kinder year. Everything happened as it happened — the war, the distance, the silence that came after — and none of it is her fault, and none of it was only mine.

I ask for one second to be admitted into evidence.

One second — in a taxi, in a hall in the dark, at a table with steam between us, in the room with the window open, at the signal with the light about to change.

One second when the thing between us was real.

I found out, years later, that a song had already filed the motion. Rupankar Bagchi, in Chotushkone — "Shetai Satyi." The refrain is my vow, sung before I ever made it:

"Jodi ek muhurter jonneo amay chao —
shetai satyi."

If you want me even for a single moment —
that is the truth.

Not "if you love me forever." Forever is not the evidence.

One moment — even one — and everything is validated. And the bridge, which I did not understand until this book:

"Shob record kora thakbe
tomar ontorborti shunnotay."
It will all remain recorded
in your inner emptiness.
That is the bargain every deep love offers: it ends, and what remains is a recording, held in the vault of the one who stayed behind. This book is that vault, opened — the pen that received the fifteen years and returns them here, in full, with the smell still in them.
If it was real once, then the fifteen years were not a mistake that time committed.
They were a life. My one whole, entire, ordinary, golden life.
If you had loved me once for even a second,
that would be my truth.
I do not need the second confirmed.
I need it recorded.
The rest is on the other side of the room. Where it belongs.
Where I have finally learned to leave it.

Epilogue — What the Signal Keeps

What remains:

The city, in the body. Sun-heated pavement. Taxi vinyl. Rain on a hot street. A kitchen at nine. Her perfume — which I will not describe further. Some smells are not for the public. They are the title deeds of private rooms.

The discipline: the truce, the line, the ordinary man at his desk, the eagle home by nine.

The work: the fortress, the studio, the books — and now the film. Made by the man the signal made.

And one more thing. The thing the whole book was built to deliver. Read it twice:

The people in the memory do not know they are being remembered. They are simply alive. The young man at the signal does not know he is standing inside the gold standard of his own life. The woman does not know the evening light on her will one day feel impossibly far away.

Nobody knows. Not you. Not now.

So — whoever is reading this in their own Tuesday, in their own city, at their own signal, in their own room with someone they have stopped noticing because they have noticed them a thousand times —

look down.

The ground is golden. This moment is already a memory. You

are simply the only one who does not know it yet.

The sad will come later. It will be sharp.

It will cut with smell.

Let it.

It is the receipt for having been alive.

— KOLKATA / ASSAM, 2011–2026

— Written in the room with the machines, September 2026

— The Beholder beholds. What is beheld beholds back.

@END